Signals Intelligence (SIGINT)

Quick briefing

Signals intelligence turns relevant observations from communications and non-communications signals into assessed information for a decision. Evaluate the quality of a report and share it with authorized recipients who need it.

Know the facts

Intelligence product · Collection provides observations. Evaluation, analysis and integration turn them into information that can support a decision.

COMINT and ELINT · Communications intelligence concerns signals such as voice or messages. Electronic intelligence concerns non-communication signals.

RDF contribution · Radio direction finding can provide directional information about an emission. A direction alone leaves important questions about the source unresolved.

Three quality aims · Accuracy asks whether the information is sound, timeliness whether it reaches the user when needed, and relevance whether it answers the decision at hand.

Corroboration · Seek independent evidence where the original report is uncertain or cannot be clarified with the source. Repeated copies of one report share its limitations.

Cycle and dissemination · Start with mission requirements. Process and analyze the available material, disseminate the assessment securely to those who need it, and use feedback to refine requirements.

Understand the reasoning

A timely report may be useful with an explicit confidence limit. Consider what decision can safely use it while substantiation is pending.

Check where reports originated before counting how many support a claim. A compromised channel or a common source can create apparent agreement.

Philippine Army classroom exercise

In a Philippine Army classroom exercise, two summaries suggest that a simulated exercise site has changed its operating hours. Both trace back to the same unverified report, and the planning team must brief soon.

Decision · How should the analyst present the apparent agreement?

Worked analysis · Treat the two summaries as one unconfirmed line of evidence. Brief the authorized team on the possible change and what remains uncertain, and seek an independent report that addresses the operating hours. This preserves a timely lead while making its evidentiary weight clear.

How to practice

1 · Write the exercise decision and the intelligence requirement it creates.

2 · Sort the instructor-provided observations by source and time. Mark which summaries derive from the same observation.

3 · Check accuracy, timeliness and relevance. Compare the claim with independent material available in the exercise.

4 · Prepare a short assessment for the designated recipients, state the uncertainty and record the next information requirement.

Check yourself

What are the two SIGINT sub-disciplines taught in the lesson? · Communications intelligence (COMINT) and electronic intelligence (ELINT).

Do two reports with the same origin independently corroborate a claim? · No. They repeat the same source, so look for an independent line of evidence.

Course source

Signals Intelligence